



Claude Code FREE Setup Guide (2026)

By **BlackBox Security** | The Ultimate AI Coding Cheat Sheet

A highly simplified, lightning-fast cheat sheet to set up **Claude Code** completely FREE using Minimax M2.5 & OpenCode. No expensive APIs, no GPU required.



Step 1: Install Dependencies

You need **Node.js (v18+)** and the **Claude Code CLI** installed on your system.



Windows

```
# 1. Install Node (using Chocolatey) or download from nodejs.org
choco install nodejs

# 2. Install Claude Code
npm install -g @anthropic-ai/claude-code
```



Mac

```
# 1. Install Node (using Homebrew)
brew install node

# 2. Install Claude Code
npm install -g @anthropic-ai/claude-code
```



Linux (Ubuntu/Debian)

```
# 1. Install Node
sudo apt update && sudo apt install nodejs npm

# 2. Install Claude Code
sudo npm install -g @anthropic-ai/claude-code
```



Step 2: Get Your Free API Key

- Go to [OpenCode.ai](#) and click "Get started with Zen".
- Login with Google/GitHub (⚠️ *Do NOT enable billing*).
- Copy your free **Minimax 2.5 API Key**.



Step 3: Configure Settings (The Magic Patch)

We need to redirect Claude Code to use our free OpenCode API instead of Anthropic's paid servers.

Open the configuration file in VS Code:

- **Windows:** `code $env:USERPROFILE\.claude\settings.json`
- **Mac/Linux:** `code ~/.claude/settings.json`

Paste this exact JSON into the file and Save:

```
{
  "env": {
    "ANTHROPIC_BASE_URL": "https://opencode.ai/zen",
    "ANTHROPIC_MODEL": "minimax-m2.5-free",
    "ANTHROPIC_API_KEY": "PASTE_YOUR_OPENCODE_API_KEY_HERE",
    "ENABLE_TOOL_SEARCH": "true"
  }
}
```

 **SECURITY WARNING:** Treat your API key like a password. Never share this `settings.json` file or commit it to a public GitHub repository.

 Step 4: Run & Test

Open your terminal and type:

```
claude
```

*It will ask if you want to use the custom API key. Select **Yes**.*

Quick Commands Reference

Command	What it does
<code>claude</code>	Starts an interactive AI coding session
<code>claude -p "build a python script"</code>	Runs a single prompt directly
<code>claude --verbose</code>	Shows detailed background logs

 Recommended Laptops for AI & Coding (2026)

If you are looking to upgrade your setup, here are my top picks:

Gaming & Heavy AI

- [Asus TUF F16](#)
- [Lenovo Legion 5](#)
- [HP Omen Ryzen 7](#)
- [MSI Katana i7](#)

Students & Daily

- [Lenovo Ideapad Slim 3](#)
- [Asus Vivobook 15](#)
- [Acer Aspire Lite](#)
- [HP 15](#)

Creators & Pro

- [MacBook Pro M5](#)
- [MacBook Air](#)

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Happy Vibe Coding! 